MANALIVE EXPEDITION

THE JOURNEY

WEEK 4
THE WOUND

SOMETHING HAPPENED

DRAFT FOR REVIEW

October 12, 2026

WEEK 4 OVERVIEW

WHAT THIS WEEK IS FOR

Week 4 walks a man back through Friday afternoon's session on the Wound, gently. It doesn't try to heal anything. That comes next week. It helps him see that something happened to his heart, that a message came with it, and that the message shaped how he lives. By Sunday he should be able to say:

> *I have a wound. It mattered. I'm starting to see what happened to my heart. I think I know the message I took from it, and I can see how it shaped me. I want to take this to God.*

HOW EVERY DAY WORKS

READING	About 150 words. A quick reminder of what happened at camp and where it shows up at home.
AUDIO	About 2 minutes from John. A handle to carry, one layer deeper, and a story.
WITH DAD	5 minutes on weekdays this week. Saturday is 8. Sunday is 3.
SHARE	Optional. Opens the alumni group with his thought ready to paste.
NOTES	Private. Day 28 shows him this week's notes in one place.
WEEKLY EMAIL	Sunday evening. One heart line per day.

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY	TITLE	CARRY THIS	WITH DAD
22 · Mon	Why Do I Do That?	**Nobody wakes up a poser**	5 min
23 · Tue	Two Questions	**Dad, watch this**	5 min
24 · Wed	His Eighth Birthday	**Go easy on the boy**	5 min
25 · Thu	Sandpaper	**Sandpaper counts**	5 min
26 · Fri	Every Wound Carries a Message	**Every wound carries a message**	5 min
27 · Sat	It Mattered	**It mattered**	8 min
28 · Sun	Bring It to Him	**Bring it to Him**	3 min

WHY DO I DO THAT?

READING

Remember Friday afternoon? You came back in from free time and your first Covenant of Silence, and the room got quieter.

Then you met Russell Duritz. Forty years old. Image consultant. Paid good money to teach people how to pose. Funny to watch. And kind of a jerk.

Last week you looked at your own poser. This week asks the next question, the same one that session asked: *Why do I do that? Where did that come from?*

Because nobody wakes up one morning and decides to build a fake version of himself. Something happened along the way.

The poser isn't the deepest thing about you. Something happened to your heart.

Go gently this week. Some of what comes up may be tender. You don't have to dig, and you don't have to do it alone. Take it to Dad. Tell one of the guys.

We're not fixing anything this week. We're just looking. Honestly.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Nobody wakes up a poser.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Three weeks before my first ManAlive camp, I started praying. Every day. And it was not a nice prayer.
>
> It went something like this. God, I don't know where You've been the last ten years. I haven't heard a word from You. So You'd better talk to me at this camp. Not some speaker. Not some sermon. You. Or I'm done.
>
> I'm pretty sure the God of the universe was real intimidated.
>
> So I show up. First small group, the leader asks what we expect from the weekend. I go first. I don't expect a thing. God hasn't talked to me in ten years. And he looks right at me and says, That's great. You're in the right place.
>
> That's who walked through the door. Bitter. Sad. Done.

But here's what I had to face. I didn't wake up one morning that way. Nobody does. You don't go to bed a regular kid and wake up a bitter man who's mad at God and everybody else.

Look at Russell Duritz. You think he just woke up a jerk one day? Something happened to him.

Same with me. Same with you.

Last week you looked at the poser. The mask. This week we ask why it's there. What happened to the boy?

Now hear me. We're not ripping anything open. We're going slow. You don't need answers today. You just need to be willing to ask.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Nobody wakes up a poser.

When you catch yourself doing your thing today, the joke, the control, the disappearing act, don't beat yourself up. Get curious. Why do I do that? Where did that come from?

Then take the question to Dad. He knows the whole story.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Bring Him one thing you caught yourself doing last week. Ask: *Father, why do I do that? Where did it start?* Then be quiet. If nothing comes, that's okay. You're just opening the door.

SHARE

Russell Duritz: funny, or a little too familiar?

YOUR NOTES

TWO QUESTIONS

READING

Before the clips on Friday afternoon, two questions were put in the room. Every man carries them. Most of us have never said them out loud.

Do I have what it takes?

Am I the apple of my father's eye?

That second one is simple. Do you see me, Dad? Do you want me? Do you like having me around?

Watch any little boy at a swimming pool. He climbs up on the edge and yells it. *Dad, watch this!* Then he jumps, and comes up looking for one face.

Both questions, in three words.

A boy starts asking them long before he has words for them. And how they got answered shaped more of your life than you'd guess.

Maybe yours got answered well. Maybe they barely got answered at all. Most of us are somewhere in between.

You don't have to sort it out today. Just notice that the questions are still in there.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Dad, watch this.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> You ever been at the pool when a kid yells, Dad, watch this?
>
> He climbs out, runs to the edge, and checks. Is Dad looking? Then he jumps. And the very first thing he does when he comes up out of the water is look for his dad's face.
>
> Every boy does that. And he's not really asking about the cannonball. He's asking two things. Do I have what it takes? And am I the apple of my father's eye? Do you see me? Do you like what you see?

I was that boy too. When I was eight or ten, my dad took me camping in Arkansas, and it poured. Stuck in a tent, and I'm bouncing off the walls. Dad digs out this big flashlight, props it up, and we played cards while the rain came down.

One of the best memories of my life. Because that night, one of those questions got answered. I was the apple of my dad's eye.

I know my story isn't everybody's. Some of you had a dad who was gone, or a dad you were scared of. Hear me. Your questions are still in there. They don't go away because nobody answered them.

And they didn't stop when you grew up. Every time you need the boss to notice, or your wife to see how hard you're trying, that's the same boy on the edge of the pool.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Dad, watch this.

You don't have to figure out how your questions got answered. Just notice the boy who's still asking.

Then take him to the Father. Tell Him which question is loudest in you right now.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, which of those two questions is still loudest in me?* Then listen. Don't grade the answer. Just notice it.

SHARE

A good memory with your dad, or with a man who was like a dad to you.

YOUR NOTES

HIS EIGHTH BIRTHDAY

READING

Then came the scene that made the room go quiet. Little Russell's eighth birthday.

He gets in a fight at school. His mom, sick and not supposed to leave the house, has to come get him. His dad comes home scared and angry, and the words land on an eight-year-old. *Grow up*.

Then the question that wrecked the room: *Did I do it?*

His dad wasn't a monster. He was a scared man about to lose his wife. Fathers are wounded men too.

But an eight-year-old can't think like a forty-year-old. He doesn't hear fear. He hears his dad. And he carries something out of that room.

Every man watching felt for that kid. Right away.

Here's the strange part. We're quick to have compassion on Russell, and slow to have it on the boy we were. We call him weak. We tell him to grow up.

Today, go easy on the boy.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Go easy on the boy.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Do you have a picture of yourself as a little boy?
>
> I don't have a lot of memories from being a kid. But I remember Saturday morning cartoons. I remember my bike. I'd build a ramp and jump it, over and over.
>
> And Legos. Man, I loved Legos. I could build for hours. Nothing I made ever looked good. It all looked terrible. But it was a blast.
>
> Most of the time, what I wanted was for my dad to notice me. To do something with me. To play.

And the thing that made my stomach drop? Getting in trouble. I hated it. And it seemed like I was in trouble a lot.

Here's what got me on Friday. When little Russell asked, did I do it, every man in that room was on his side. Nobody thought, toughen up, kid. We all wanted to grab him and tell him it'd be okay.

But turn that around to the boy we were, and a lot of us go cold. He was too soft. Too needy. Too much. He should've handled it better. Grow up.

Think about that. The voice a lot of us use on the boy inside is the same thing Russell's dad yelled at him.

In the movie, big Russell can't stand the kid at first. He's annoyed by him. Wants him gone. Things only start to change when he stops and actually looks at him.

That's all I'm asking today. Not to dig. Not to go hunting for the worst memory you've got. Just look at the kid. The way you looked at Russell.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Go easy on the boy.

When you hear that voice today, what's wrong with you, get it together, notice it. Ask whose voice that really is.

Then take the boy to Dad. Don't explain him. Don't fix him. Just bring him.

Go easy on the boy.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Picture yourself as a boy. Ask: *Father, show me that boy. What was he carrying?* Then just look, and listen. Don't fix anything. If nothing comes, that's okay. Sit with him anyway.

SHARE

Got a picture of yourself as a kid? Post it.

YOUR NOTES

SANDPAPER

READING

After the clips on Friday, a couple of guys got up and told their own stories. Short. Honest. No bow on top.

Maybe one of them had a hard dad. And maybe one had a good one, a dad who loved him, and something still landed wrong.

That second guy was there for a reason. He was there for the man in the back thinking, *My dad was a good guy. This isn't about me.*

Here's what that session said: a wound doesn't matter because it sounds terrible. It matters because of what happened in your heart.

Some wounds are one blow. Some are sandpaper. One scrape doesn't do much. The same scrape, again and again, and eventually it bleeds.

Don't compare yours to anybody's. Not the worst story in the room, and not the mildest.

And if yours is heavy, the kind of thing no kid should ever carry, go slow. You set the pace, with Dad.

It doesn't need to be dramatic. It needs to be true.

> CARRY THIS
> **Sandpaper counts.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> My dad is a good man. I want you to hear that first. We have a great relationship today.
>
> When I was a kid, money got really tight. Dad had fought for custody of me, and that cost a lot. So he worked a regular job all day, then came home and worked again at night. He became a workaholic. Not because he didn't love me. Because life was pressing on him.
>
> And under that pressure, what came out was this. You need to be better. You need to be better than me.
>
> I'd mow the lawn, and he'd come out. You should have cut it this way. So next time I'd do it his way, and miss one little strip. Son, you didn't do it the way I told you.

I brought home a report card. Seven A's and one B. And he said, Son, I'm really disappointed in you. Why'd you get a B? You're smarter than that.

Folding clothes. Stacking wood. Didn't matter what it was.

Now, that might sound small. My dad never beat me. But to a boy looking for his father's approval, that's big stuff.

It's like sandpaper. Drag it across your hand once, it's rough, no big deal. Drag it again and again and again, and eventually you're bleeding. That's what happened to my heart.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Sandpaper counts.

You don't need the worst story in the room for yours to matter. And you don't need to make your dad the bad guy to admit something happened.

So today, don't go hunting for something dramatic. Just ask Dad what happened to your heart. Not the facts. Your heart. What did that boy feel?

Sandpaper counts. So does yours.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, what happened to my heart?* Not what happened. What happened in you. Then listen. If it starts to feel like too much, stop there and just sit with Him.

SHARE

Did one of the stories at camp sound a little like yours? No details needed.

YOUR NOTES

EVERY WOUND CARRIES A MESSAGE

READING

Remember what came after the stories? The wound isn't only what happened. Somewhere in it, your heart came to believe something.

Nobody sat you down and said it. You just picked it up. And you've been living like it's true ever since.

A boy who decides *I'm on my own* grows into a man who has to control everything. A boy who decides *I'll never measure up* grows into a man working himself into the ground to finally be impressive enough. And the poser grows up right around the message, like a fence.

Here's the strange part. The message usually ends up bigger than the event. What happened lasted a few minutes. What you came to believe can last for decades.

Nobody can tell you what yours is. Don't borrow somebody else's, and don't pick one off a list.

Just start asking: *Because of what happened, what did I come to believe?*

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Every wound carries a message.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> For me, it came down to one sentence. Nothing I do is good enough.
>
> My dad never said those words. Not once. But that's what my heart took from the lawn and the report card and the stacked wood. A boy can't hear "you could do better" that many times and not draw a conclusion.
>
> And here's the thing about a message. Once you believe it, you start living like it's true. You don't even notice. It just runs in the background.
>
> For me it showed up everywhere.
>
> I used to manage a call center. And no matter how good my team did, my boss wanted more. He'd find a way to push for more, every time.
>
> So I tried harder. And harder. I was trying to please him the same way I used to try to please my dad.

> And eventually, I just gave up. I decided it was going to be wrong no matter what I did.
>
> And it went darker than that. Years later, when I was living a double life, that same message was sitting right underneath it. Nothing I do is good enough anyway. So what does it matter?
>
> That's how a message works. The thing that happened was over in a few minutes. The message stuck around for years.
>
> **So here's what I want you to carry today. Every wound carries a message.**
>
> Now, I'm not going to tell you what yours is. I'd probably be wrong. And please don't borrow mine. Yours might be something completely different.
>
> You don't have to fight it today, either. You don't have to fix it. This week is just about seeing it. You can't bring something to God you've never named.
>
> So ask Dad. Because of what happened, what did I come to believe?
>
> Then listen. Every wound carries a message. Let Him help you hear yours.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, because of what happened, what did I come to believe?* Then listen. Don't force it. If you're not sure yet, write down your best guess. That's enough for today.

SHARE

One thing about yourself that's made more sense since camp.

YOUR NOTES

IT MATTERED

READING

The last clip on Friday afternoon was Good Will Hunting.

Will is a genius. He knows everything. So when Sean holds up his file and says *it's not your fault*, Will has an answer ready. *I know*.

Sean says it again. *I know*. Again. And again. Until it finally gets past his head.

A lot of us live right there. I know it was hard. Everybody had it hard. Other guys had it worse. It wasn't that big a deal.

That's how men handle a wound. We shrink it. Or we shrug it off. Or we decide it's just who we are.

But what happened to your heart mattered. You don't have to make it bigger. You don't have to make it smaller. You don't have to fix it today.

Take a little longer with Dad today. And if what comes up feels like too much to hold, don't dig alone. Call one of the guys. And talking to a good counselor isn't a weak move. It's a strong one.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **It mattered.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> That scene still gets me. Every time.
>
> I've seen it more times than I can count. I know exactly what's coming. And every time Sean says it, something in my heart cries out.
>
> Because here's what I hear underneath it. A big part of what came out of me wasn't my fault. I was programmed this way. I was taught this way. A boy who heard that nothing he did was good enough didn't choose that. He learned it.
>
> For years, I never called it a wound. I just figured I had a crappy childhood.
>
> My parents were divorced. My mom didn't come around much. And she told me all kinds of things about my stepmom, that I shouldn't like her. So when my dad and stepmom

disciplined me, which is normal, it just felt hard. Mean, even. And when I'd go visit my mom, she didn't discipline me at all.

I felt like I didn't have anybody. My childhood just felt sad. The part I really remember being good was high school. Band. My friends.

That's how I talked about it. Sad. Hard. Just how it was. I knew all of it. I just never let it be something that happened to my heart.

That's what Will does. He's not lying. He does know. He knows it up here. He just won't let it anywhere near his heart. Because if it gets in, he might have to feel it.

Most of us do the same thing. We keep it in our heads, where it's safe.

So here's what I want you to carry today. It mattered.

Not, it was the worst thing that ever happened to anybody. Not, it's an excuse. Just this. What happened to that boy mattered.

It's Saturday. Take longer with Dad today. Eight minutes. Tell Him what happened, the honest version, without the "but it wasn't that bad" tacked on the end.

I'm not going to tell you what He'll say. That's between you and Him. Just bring it. And listen.

And if it gets heavy, you don't carry it by yourself. Call one of the guys. That's what they're for.

It mattered.

WITH DAD 8 MINUTES

Tell Him what happened, the honest version. No "but it wasn't that bad." Then ask: *Father, will You look at this with me?* Listen, and write down what comes. If nothing comes, stay anyway. If it gets too heavy, stop and call one of the guys.

SHARE

Good Will Hunting. Did that scene get you too?

YOUR NOTES

BRING IT TO HIM

READING

Four weeks home.

This week you went back to the quietest hour of the weekend. Russell. The two questions. A boy on his eighth birthday. Men telling the truth about their stories. Will, finally hearing it.

And then they sent you out. The second Covenant of Silence. An hour alone with God and whatever had come up.

Maybe that hour was huge. Maybe you sat on a log and nothing happened. Both are okay.

That's still the invitation. Not to fix it. Not to figure it all out. Just to bring it to Him, honestly, and listen.

Your notes from this week are right below. Read back through them slowly. Be kind to the man who wrote them.

Today, rest.

And if one question is sitting with you, let it sit: *If something happened to my heart, what does Jesus want to do with it?*

Tomorrow we start there.

> CARRY THIS
> **Bring it to Him.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Years ago, right before I sent a room full of men out into that second Covenant of Silence, I told them one thing.
>
> If you ask Him a question and you hear something, write it down. I don't care what it is. Don't sit there going, well, I wonder if that was God. Don't wonder if. Write it down. The Father wants to speak.
>
> I still believe that.

This week you've been doing a smaller version of that hour, a few minutes at a time. You asked why you do what you do. You remembered the two questions. You looked at the boy. You let sandpaper count. You listened for the message. And maybe yesterday, you let it matter.

That's a lot. If this week stirred things up, that's not a sign you did it wrong. It's a sign you were honest.

And if not much came, that's okay too. Keep the door open. He's patient.

So here's what I want you to carry into this week. Bring it to Him.

Not fixed. Not figured out. Not cleaned up. Just honest. Whatever you found this week doesn't belong in a box in the garage. It belongs with Him.

Today, rest. Read back through your notes. Text one of the guys and tell him you're still in.

And sit with that question I left you. If something happened to my heart, what does Jesus want to do with it?

We'll start there tomorrow. Bring it to Him.

WITH DAD 3 MINUTES

Say: *Father, here's what I found this week. I'm bringing it to You.* Then just be with Him. Nothing to fix.

SHARE

One line about your fourth week home.

YOUR WEEK IN THE APP: HIS NOTES FROM DAYS 22 TO 28, FILLED IN

Same as Day 7: each note he wrote this week, with the day, the "Carry this" line, and the With Dad question. Only days he wrote show up.

YOUR NOTES ON DAY 28

SUNDAY EVENING, AFTER DAY 28

THE WEEK 4 EMAIL

Same template as Week 1. Only the seven day lines are new.

From: The Journey <jpulley@manaliveexpedition.com>
Subject: Week four is in the books. You're caught up.

Mike,

Four weeks home. Maybe you did every day. Maybe you missed a few. Either way, you're not behind, and there's nothing to apologize for. Here's the heart of the week, in case any of it slipped by.

Day 22, Why Do I Do That? Russell didn't wake up a jerk, and you didn't wake up a poser. Something happened along the way. Reread Day 22 ›

Day 23, Two Questions. Do I have what it takes? Am I the apple of my father's eye? Every boy is asking. Dad, watch this. Reread Day 23 ›

Day 24, His Eighth Birthday. We had compassion for little Russell in a heartbeat. Go easy on the boy you were, too. Reread Day 24 ›

Day 25, Sandpaper. A wound doesn't have to be dramatic to matter. Small scrapes, again and again, still draw blood. Sandpaper counts. Reread Day 25 ›

Day 26, Every Wound Carries a Message. What happened lasted a few minutes. What you came to believe can last for years. Only you and Dad can name yours. Reread Day 26 ›

Day 27, It Mattered. Like Will, we say "I know" and keep it in our heads. What happened to your heart mattered. Reread Day 27 ›

Day 28, Bring It to Him. Not fixed. Not figured out. Just honest. Bring it to Him. Reread Day 28 ›

Your notes from this week are waiting for you on Day 28. Only you can see them.

Read your week ›

That's the week. If you just read this, you're caught up. Tomorrow we start fresh.

Strength and Honor,
Pulley

FOR YOUR REVIEW

DECISIONS MADE IN THIS DRAFT

- **Recognition only, no healing.** The week walks the session in order: poser to wound (22), the two questions (23), the "Grow Up" scene (24), responders and good-dad wounds (25), the message (26), Good Will Hunting and "it mattered" (27), the second Covenant (28). No forgiveness, renunciation, replacing lies, or declaring what God says. With Dad prompts ask open questions and never put words in God's mouth. Day 26 says outright: don't fight the message yet, just name it.
- **The two questions use the exact ManAlive wording.** "Do you see me? Do you want me?" appears only as an explanation of the second, as the spec allows.
- **Gentleness built in.** Day 22 sets the frame (go slow, don't dig alone, Dad and one of the guys). Day 25 speaks to men carrying something heavy ("you set the pace"). Day 27's reading carries the one counselor line: "isn't a weak move. It's a strong one." Every With Dad prompt has a way out if nothing comes or it gets too heavy.
- **Fathers aren't villains.** Day 24 says Russell's dad was scared, not a monster. Day 25 leads with "My dad is a good man… great relationship today," so the good-dad man knows this week is for him too.
- **Held WOUND story on Day 27.** Good Will Hunting still gets you every time; "I was programmed this way, taught this way." It stays recognition: you don't say what God will say.
- **Your own 2019 Wound talk, retold. Please check the details:** Day 22, praying for three weeks before your first camp ("You'd better talk to me… or I'm done"), "I don't expect a thing" in small group, and the leader's "You're in the right place" (softened from "a damn thing"; Darrell and Matt left unnamed). Day 23, cards by flashlight in a tent at an Arkansas lake (the McDonald's bike rides were cut for length). Day 25, Dad's custody costs and two jobs, the lawn, seven A's and a B, folding clothes and stacking wood, the sandpaper picture. Day 26, the message "nothing I do is good enough" and one non-graphic line tying it to the double life. Day 28, your 2019 send-off: "Don't wonder if. Write it down."
- **Four story slots** (Days 23, 24, 26, 27). Days 22, 25 and 28 use your told stories instead.
- **Left out on purpose:** the mother wound you mentioned in 2019, other speakers' and responders' stories, and the removed "I'm a Loser" clip (Chester, the jets). No jail story slot: it seems to fit a later week better. Tell me if it belongs on Day 26.
- **Day 28's bridge** asks "If something happened to my heart, what does Jesus want to do with it?" without answering it. Week 5 picks it up.

- **With Dad** is 5 minutes on weekdays, 8 on Saturday, 3 on Sunday.

OVERALL NOTES ON WEEK 4